

Version 1.8 – September 2026. Adds explicit mandatory pattern check to Check 5.8 (References / Rule 2.8 audit): Check 5.8 must now specifically search every References section for the ‘Guidebook interpretation supplied for...’ artefact string, confirmed as a recurring generator artefact found across all 20 COP documents and previously in AAC.9-13. All prior content preserved unchanged.

HCO Full v2 Policy Rewrite – Master Rulebook and Verification Checklist

Consolidated edition – combines the original rulebook, the project handoff’s recurring-failure-pattern notes, and every defect actually found and fixed during the HRM / PRE / IMS / COP completion sessions. Generated for chapter-by-chapter cross-checking, starting fresh from AAC.

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This is the single reference to check any chapter's raw source dump and any generated policy .docx against. It replaces the original 8-page rulebook – everything from that document is preserved here, with the failure patterns that were only theoretical there now marked with a confirmed real-world hit from this project.

For each chapter, in order:

- Get the real NABH HCO Full Accreditation 6th Edition source – the Standards PDF and the Guidebook – for that chapter specifically. See Section 0: Source Verification before touching anything else.
- Pull or receive the raw OE/Guidebook dump for the chapter.

- Cross-check the dump against the real Guidebook pages, not just against itself. This is what has caught every real error so far.
- Draft plain-language content following Sections 1–3.
- Build the .docx.
- Run every check in Section 5: The Verification Loop – all of it, not a subset – before treating anything as done.
- Open the actual file in Word. Not optional. See Section 5.15.
- Stage and commit per Section 6: Git Discipline.

Section 0 – Source Verification (check this first, every time)

This project has already shipped one near-miss: an attempt to build the IMS chapter from SHCO 3rd Edition build scripts that were sitting in the repo, when the actual target is HCO Full Accreditation 6th Edition – a different NABH programme with different OE text, different OE counts, and different chapter numbering. It was caught before anything got drafted, but only because it was checked.

Before drafting anything for a chapter:

- Confirm the source material is explicitly HCO Full Accreditation, 6th Edition. If a script, JSON file, or dump references SHCO, a different edition number, or doesn't say which programme it's from, stop and confirm before using it.
- Confirm the OE count for the chapter matches the official chapter table (Section 7 of this document) before drafting a single standard. A mismatch (like AAC being treated as 8 standards when it has 13) is a scoping error, not a content error, and it compounds silently.
- When extracting from a PDF, do not assume a printed page number equals the PDF's internal page index. A 242-page PDF's internal page 293 is not necessarily the page printed as '293' in the document. If page-index extraction produces nonsense (wrong chapter, garbled text), stop and ask for the correct page range rather than guessing.
- The safest source is the person supplying the actual Guidebook PDF pages for the chapter, the same way PRE (pages 176–195) and IMS (pages 293–311) were supplied this session. A raw dump alone is not enough to trust – see Section 0.1.

0.1 – Raw dumps are a starting point, not a source of truth

A raw dump can be well-organised and still contain two kinds of content that must be told apart before drafting:

- Sourced content: the verbatim OE text and the Guidebook's own Interpretation paragraph. This is safe to draft from.
- Dump-author commentary: 'Achievement status' narratives, worked audit-guidance examples, or 'Documentation' notes that describe what an assessor might look for. This is often useful context, but it is not Guidebook text, and it has already been caught inventing specific numbers that don't exist in the source (see Rule 2.6 and Pattern G below).

When a dump gives you a specific number – a frequency, a day count, a percentage – trace it back to the actual OE or Interpretation sentence it came from. If it only appears in a commentary/status section, leave it out.

Section 1 – The Core Principle

A policy rewrite has two separate jobs, and they must not be confused:

- Structure/formatting – title format, section order, table layout, bracket rules. This is mechanical and safe to copy from an approved reference document.
- Content – the actual rules, obligations, and explanations. This is not mechanical. It must be pulled fresh from each standard’s own source text (OE + Guidebook interpretation) and checked every single time, even though the pattern looks the same.

Never let confidence in the structure create false confidence in the content. A document can be perfectly formatted and still contain a wrong rule. A document can also be perfectly worded and still be structurally broken in a way plain-text review won’t catch – see Pattern H below, found in this project’s own IMS build.

Section 2 – Content Rules

2.1 – Match the source’s exact strength of obligation

NABH source text uses different modal words on purpose: shall / must (mandatory), may / could (optional or an example), should (recommended). A rewritten rule must preserve that exact strength – never upgrade a ‘may’ into a ‘must’.

Do: Pull the raw OE sentence and the Guidebook interpretation before writing any rule. Write out a modal-strength table (which words are shall/may/could) before drafting rules. When a source lists something as one possible example (‘could be in the form of a registration certificate’), phrase it as an example, not the only accepted method.

Don’t: Don’t turn ‘may require formal orientation’ into ‘Do not skip formal orientation.’ (Real error, ROM.1 draft 1.) Don’t turn ‘selection may be based on qualifications...’ into a required criterion. (Real error, ROM.1 draft 1.) Don’t invent enumerated failure scenarios the source never lists.

2.2 – Never reuse another standard’s sentences or reasoning

Each standard’s rules must trace only to its own OE text and interpretation – never copied or adapted from a sibling standard, even when the topics feel related.

Do: Run an explicit overlap check before presenting a draft: which sentences also appear in previously-approved documents, and is that overlap genuine shared boilerplate (training sentence, distribution line) or borrowed subject-matter content that belongs to the other standard? State the check’s result out loud, even if the answer is ‘no reuse found.’

Don’t: Don’t reuse a chapter-specific exclusion list. (ROM.1’s exclusion list was copied wholesale into a ROM.6 draft – wrong duties entirely.) Don’t let two different standards’ Reference sections list the same internal artefacts unless those artefacts genuinely belong to both.

2.3 – CORE / asterisk status lives in exactly one place

Objective elements are asterisked (documentation required) or marked CORE (zero tolerance) in the official standards data. This status must survive into the rewritten document – but only once.

Do: Put CORE/asterisk status only in a 'Level' column in the Traceability table, pulled from the actual inventory data – never transcribed by eye. Give the Quality Monitoring section a working cross-reference back to that Level column, with the right section number.

Don't: Don't write 'This objective element is asterisked...' or 'This is a CORE objective element...' as inline sentences inside the plain-language 'What we do' prose. It breaks the readable voice and duplicates the Traceability table. Don't drop the CORE/asterisk marker entirely – the underlying obligation still needs a real referent somewhere in the document.

2.4 – Abbreviations tables are derived, not copied

Do: List only abbreviations that actually appear in that specific document's rendered text. Derive this mechanically – scan the rendered body (excluding the glossary itself) and keep only abbreviations with at least one real occurrence.

Don't: Don't copy a fixed abbreviations list from a previous chapter's approved document. A governance policy listing AERB (a radiation authority) makes the document look template-assembled.

2.5 – Policies must be understandable without NABH knowledge

Every policy document must be fully understandable to a reader with zero knowledge of NABH standards, chapter codes, or accreditation terminology. The document's job is to tell hospital staff what to do – not to map onto an accreditation framework the reader may never have heard of.

This means:

- The Purpose section's boundary statement must describe what topics this policy does NOT cover in plain language (e.g., 'This policy does not cover patient registration or admission – those are covered in other hospital policies'), WITHOUT the trailing sentence 'The other [Chapter] standards have their own policies too' or any similar phrase that only makes sense to someone who already knows what a 'standard' or 'chapter' is in NABH's system.
- No standard code (e.g., 'AAC.1.a-d', 'COP.6') may appear anywhere in the Purpose, Scope, or body prose sections – not even the document's own standard number. Describe content by topic, not by code. ('It covers defining services in line with community needs, diagnostic and treatment capability with qualified personnel, department scope, and permanent bi-lingual display' – not 'It covers AAC.1.a-d: ...').
- Sections 11 (Traceability table) and 12 (Required Records / Evidence Checklist) are explicitly EXEMPT from this rule – these are reference/audit sections where NABH codes are expected and useful, and require no change.

This rule applies retroactively to all previously-built documents, not just newly drafted ones – because the underlying framing (assuming NABH literacy) was baked into every chapter's Purpose/Scope generation.

2.5d – No undefined internal shorthand terms [NEW v1.6]

A policy document must not introduce a compound or shorthand label for a concept (e.g., 'temporary-holding over-run,' 'priority-flag lapse') and then use that label elsewhere in the document as if it were self-explanatory, unless the label is explicitly defined at first use.

This applies whether the underlying concept is explained earlier in the same document or not – a reader may encounter any single sentence in isolation (a training extract, an audit excerpt, a quoted passage) and must be able to understand it without needing to have read the rest of the document first.

Fix pattern: either (a) spell out the concept in plain language at the point of use instead of using a shorthand label, or (b) if a shorthand term is genuinely useful for a repeated concept, define it in full the first time it appears (e.g., ‘a patient remaining on a temporary bed beyond the defined limit – a temporary-holding over-run’) and only use the bare shorthand in later occurrences within the same document.

This rule was added after AAC.2’s ‘temporary-holding over-run’ was found used in a Quality Monitoring sentence without ever being defined anywhere in the document – a reader encountering that sentence alone would not know what it meant.

2.5e – Deferred definitions must name where the definition lives [NEW v1.6]

When a policy defers a specific number, threshold, or procedure to ‘the organisation’s defined [X]’ (rather than stating the value directly), it must also state WHERE that definition actually lives – e.g., a named SOP, a specific role responsible for setting it (e.g. ‘as defined by the Quality Coordinator in the RCA procedure’), or a cross-reference to a real governance document.

A bare deferral with no named home for the definition (e.g., ‘the organisation’s defined recurrence threshold applies,’ with nothing else) is not acceptable – it reads as a promise pointing at nothing and gives hospital staff no way to actually find or act on the value. This is functionally as ungrounded as a fabricated number, just vaguer instead of false.

This rule was added after reviewing AAC.1-8’s root-cause-analysis recurrence-threshold fixes, which uniformly used ‘the organisation’s defined recurrence threshold applies’ without stating where that threshold is actually documented.

2.5f – No reference to a resource that isn’t provided or located [NEW v1.7]

A policy document must not tell the reader to “refer to” or “see” another resource (a Glossary, an Appendix, another policy, a table) unless that resource either (a) actually exists within this same document, or (b) is named precisely enough to be found — a specific document title, section number, page reference, or URL.

A bare reference like “refer to the Glossary” with no glossary present anywhere in the document, and no indication of where such a glossary can be found, is a dead pointer and must be fixed by either:

- including the actual definition directly in the document at the point of use, or
- naming precisely where the resource lives (e.g., “see the NABH Guidebook to Accreditation Standards for Hospitals, 6th Edition, Glossary of Terms”).

This rule was added after COP.1 was found instructing readers to “refer to the Glossary” for two specific term definitions, in three separate places, when no glossary existed anywhere in the document or was named as a locatable external source.

2.6 – Never invent a specific date, number, or deadline the source doesn't give

Real error caught in a comparison test: a model asked to fill in a Document Control table invented 'Effective Date: October 2026' and 'Next Review: October 2027' – plausible-looking, completely fabricated.

Confirmed hit this session: PRE.7 and PRE.8's first build included 'quarterly PREM reporting,' 'complaints within 7 days,' and 'feedback tabulated monthly' – none of it stated anywhere in the actual OE or Guidebook interpretation. It had leaked in from the raw dump's own illustrative 'Achievement status' commentary (see Section 0.1). It had to be stripped and rebuilt.

Do: Leave a real blank – '_____' – for any date, effective date, or review date not supplied as part of the source data. Only state a specific number (a frequency, a deadline, a threshold) when the OE or Guidebook text actually states that number. When a dump gives you a number, trace it to its literal source sentence before using it. If you can't find it in the OE or Interpretation text itself, don't use it.

Don't: Don't fill in a plausible-sounding date, version number, or interval just because the template has a field for it. Don't carry a dump's 'Achievement status' or 'Documentation' narrative numbers into policy text as if they were sourced obligations.

2.7 – No leftover template boilerplate

Don't include, unless it appears in an already-approved reference document:

- 'This policy covers all N requirements under this standard, listed in detail below.'
- 'Do not skip: [restated OE sentence]' as a non-negotiable rule – this is a label, not a rule. (See Pattern F.)
- 'Hospital Name implements X so that [restated OE sentence]' or 'This policy says how Hospital Name meets standard X.'
- Internal build artefacts: md5 hashes, OCR file paths, draft_label values, 'Method note (from guidebook interpretation):' – none of this belongs in a document a hospital or assessor reads.

2.8 – References lists external authority only

(Added after the AAC.1-8 audit. Confirmed to recur in PRE.1-4 – see Pattern I.)

The References section exists to cite outside sources that justify what the policy says – the NABH Guidebook, ISO/NABL standards, named Acts. It is not a second copy of the hospital's own records.

Do: Keep References limited to external authority: the NABH Guidebook citation for the standard, and any named external standard or law actually stated in the source (ISO 15189:2022, NABL 112, AERB, PC-PNDT Act, the Indian Nursing Council Act, the Code of Medical Ethics, etc.) – never invented ones. Let the Required Records / Evidence Checklist section be the only place the hospital's own internal documents are listed.

Don't: Don't add a bullet like 'Internal documents of «Hospital Name»: ...' to References. If the same list already appears in the Required Records section, repeating it in References is pure duplication. If a specific internal document genuinely needs to be pointed to from References (rare), it must carry its own document number and revision.

2.9 – Filling NABH’s deliberate gaps with verified external practice [extended v1.4]

Where NABH’s source text deliberately leaves a number, frequency, or method undefined (using ‘may,’ ‘could,’ ‘at appropriate intervals,’ ‘within a defined time frame,’ or similar), the hospital may adopt a specific practice based on a verified, internationally recognised standard or professional body’s published guidance – provided:

- The source is real, current, and independently verifiable via a live, working link.
- Policy text is honest about authorship: phrased as ‘the organisation’s defined practice, based on [source]’ – never implied to be an NABH mandate.
- The source is listed in the standard’s References section as a named external authority – the same treatment NABH’s own Guidebook uses (e.g., AAC.7.a citing ISO 15189:2022 and NABL 112).
- This never overrides a number NABH does explicitly state – it only fills genuine, confirmed gaps.
- Every source must be actually searched, fetched, and confirmed live at drafting time – never invented or assumed by an AI drafting tool. A plausible-sounding but unverified citation is the same class of error as a fabricated number (see Pattern G) and is treated with equal severity.

When multiple credible external sources conflict on a value, the following priority order applies for source selection:

- NABH’s own text (always wins if it states a number – see Rule 2.1).
- WHO (World Health Organization) guidance, where applicable.
- The Joint Commission (TJC) or Joint Commission International (JCI) patient-safety standards – cite whichever body actually published the specific standard in question; never treat TJC and JCI as interchangeable, since they are related but distinct organizations with separate published standards.
- Other named professional/accrediting bodies (e.g., CAP, ACEP, ISO, NABL) – used when none of the above have published on the specific point.
- Peer-reviewed research findings – used only when no accrediting or professional body has published a direct standard.

Higher-priority sources override lower ones on conflict. The rationale for the source actually selected must be stated in the policy text (per Rule 2.9’s authorship-honesty requirement), and if two sources at the SAME priority level disagree, the discrepancy must be disclosed per Rule 2.10 rather than silently resolved.

2.10 – Every stated time value must have a verified source, cited in References [NEW – v1.3]

Any time-based value stated as a firm rule in a policy document – an hour, a day count, a week, a month, a quarter, a year, or any other specific duration or frequency – must satisfy one of these two conditions, with no exception:

- The value is taken directly from NABH’s own OE or Interpretation text (e.g., AAC.4.c’s ‘24 hours,’ AAC.6.g’s ‘one hour’). No citation is needed beyond the existing NABH Guidebook reference already in this standard’s References section.

- The value is NOT stated by NABH (NABH leaves it undefined, uses ‘may,’ ‘could,’ ‘at appropriate intervals,’ ‘within a defined time frame,’ or is simply silent). In this case, per Rule 2.9, the value must be based on a verified, real, independently-checkable external authority – and that source MUST be named in the References section of that same standard’s document, with enough detail (author/body, publication, and a working reference) that a reader can verify it themselves.

There is no third option. A time value that is neither NABH-sourced nor externally verified and cited is a Rule 2.6/Pattern G violation and must be fixed before the document is considered complete – either by sourcing it properly (per Rule 2.9) or by removing the specific number and using NABH’s own open-ended language instead (as done for AAC.5’s early-warning review, where no verified external source existed for that specific claim).

When two credible external sources disagree (e.g., two accreditation or professional bodies proposing different values for the same practice), the discrepancy must be disclosed rather than silently picking one – either by naming the source actually adopted and why, or by flagging the disagreement to the person for a decision, as was done for AAC.2’s temporary-bed holding time (Joint Commission’s 4 hours vs. CMS’s 6 hours).

This rule applies retroactively: every time value in all 100 already-built documents must be checked against this rule, not just newly drafted content.

Section 3 – Structure and Formatting Rules

3.1 – Title

- Format: ‘Policy on [Subject]’ – e.g. ‘Policy on Those Responsible for Governance’.
- Uses the Word ‘Title’ paragraph style – not Heading 1, not plain bold text.
- No chapter/edition subtitle line underneath.

3.2 – Guillemets (« »)

- Keep « » brackets only around ‘Hospital Name’ – this is the one placeholder the delivery system finds and replaces automatically.
- Every other placeholder (Medical Superintendent, department in-charge, quarterly, 90 days, role names, timeframes, frequencies, etc.) is written as plain text.

3.3 – Staff acknowledgement sentence

- Format: ‘I have read the Policy on [Subject] of «Hospital Name». I will follow the processes described.’
- Check for the ‘Policy on X policy of Y’ stutter whenever the title changes.

3.4 – Section order

In this exact sequence:

- Document control (table)
- Statement of intent
- Purpose
- Scope

- Policy standards
- Non-negotiable rules
- What we do (with 5.1, 5.2... subsections)
- Stop-work authority – only if the standard actually has stop-work data in its source (see Pattern E – this is the single most commonly mis-applied rule in the whole project)
- Governance and responsibility (table)
- Quality monitoring
- Training and staff acknowledgement (with signature table)
- Distribution
- Abbreviations (table)
- Traceability to NABH HCO Full Accreditation 6th Edition [Code] (table, with Level column)
- Required Records / Evidence Checklist
- References – LAST numbered section, immediately before Disclaimer
- Disclaimer (fixed paragraphs, not numbered)

When section numbers shift because a standard has no Stop-work section, check every internal 'Section N' cross-reference in the document – a Level-column reference or a Quality Monitoring reference can silently point at the wrong number.

3.5 – Word paragraph styles

- Main title: Title
- Top-level sections: Heading 1
- Subsections (5.1, 5.2...): Heading 2
- Body text: Normal
- Non-negotiable rules: List Number (native Word numbering – see Pattern H)
- Bulleted lists (References, Evidence Checklist): List Bullet

Real error caught: a document generated by cloning another file's raw XML had its title on Heading 1 instead of Title, and every top-level section demoted one level. Always verify the actual paragraph style objects, not just how the text looks when skimmed.

3.6 – Document control table

6 rows – 4 columns: Document No./Version, Issue No./Review due, Date created/Date of implementation, then Prepared by / Reviewed by / Approved by – each spanning the remaining columns as one merged cell.

Prepared/Reviewed/Approved rows must be actual table rows with merged cells – not separate paragraphs sitting below the table.

Section 4 – Recurring Failure Patterns

Every pattern below has caused a real, confirmed error in this project. When auditing a new chapter, check for all of them – not just the ones that feel likely for that chapter's subject matter.

Pattern A – Modal-strength inflation

Turning 'may' or 'could' into 'must' or 'shall.' See Rule 2.1.

Pattern B – Cross-standard content borrowing

Reusing a sibling standard's specific reasoning or exclusion list instead of drafting from the standard's own source. See Rule 2.2.

Pattern C – Inline CORE/asterisk narration

Writing 'this is a CORE element' in the readable prose instead of only in the Traceability table. See Rule 2.3.

Pattern D – Cross-reference codes leaking into prose

The rule against reproducing codes like 'COP.1.e' in policy prose gets violated pervasively – not just cross-chapter (AAC→PRE/COP/HRM/ROM, FMS→IPC/MOM) but same-chapter, standard-to-standard (AAC.1 citing AAC.6/8, AAC.6 citing AAC.7). A first audit pass on any chapter that only searches for cross-chapter codes will under-report the problem.

Confirmed hits: AAC.1-8 (same-chapter leaks missed by the first pass), HRM.6 (PSQ.1.a, IPC.8.a), HRM.9 (FMS.3.a). PRE.5-8 and IMS were checked and had none in source – but they still had to be checked.

When auditing any chapter, search for the chapter's own code prefix as a cross-reference target too, not just other chapters' prefixes.

Fix is always the same: replace the named code with 'covered in other hospital policies' (or, for same-standard self-references like 'AAC.1.a-d' or 'HRM.8.c-e' pointing to a different OE within the same standard, rephrase as an internal section pointer like 'Section 5.3' – those are fine to keep as internal pointers, only pointers to a different standard are the problem).

Pattern E – Stop-work tags blanket-applied to every OE in a standard

A confirmed, documented bug in generation tooling: a standard's 'Where addressed' column tags every OE with 'Section 6, Stop-work' when the actual stop-work triggers apply to only one or two specific OEs.

Confirmed hits: ROM.6 (triggers only on .d and .e, not a/b/c/f – found by manual inspection after the automated fix missed it). The same bug's source comments were found in the HRM.11/12/13 raw dump itself before any drafting began: `oe_mapping()` was documented as adding 'Section 6 Stop-work' to all OEs, when the dump's own OE-level flags confirmed real triggers exist on only 2 of 6-7 OEs per standard (HRM.11.a/d, HRM.12.a/d, HRM.13.a/c).

This was headed off successfully in HRM.11-13 by flagging it explicitly in the drafted content before building, and confirmed correct in the rendered Traceability table afterward. That is the model to repeat: state which specific OEs trigger stop-work, in writing, before the build step – don't wait to catch it after. Assume this bug is possible in any standard with stop-work data until checked, in every chapter.

Pattern F – Auto-generated non-negotiables violate Rule 2.7 by construction

A generator's default non-negotiable output can follow the pattern 'Do not skip: {OE text restated}' – which Rule 2.7 explicitly prohibits. This is a label, not a rule.

Every standard's non-negotiables section must be hand-written as a real prohibition, phrased as an actual 'do not do X' instruction with its own logic – not a mechanical restatement of the OE sentence with 'Do not skip' bolted on front. Any chapter using auto-generation for this section should be checked for this pattern specifically.

Pattern G – Dump commentary treated as sourced fact

(New this session – see Section 0.1 and Rule 2.6.)

A raw dump's own 'Achievement status' or 'Documentation' narrative – which describes what an assessor might plausibly look for – can contain specific numbers (a frequency, a day count) that do not appear anywhere in the actual OE or Guidebook interpretation text.

Confirmed hit: PRE.7 and PRE.8's build included 'quarterly,' '7 days,' and 'monthly' language sourced from exactly this kind of commentary, not from the standard's real source text. Caught by close reading against the literal Guidebook pages, not by trusting the dump.

Before using any specific number from a dump, find its literal sentence in the OE text or the Guidebook Interpretation paragraph. If it only exists in a status/commentary section, it does not go in the policy.

Pattern H – Docx-level structural bugs invisible to text review

(New this session, found in the IMS chapter build.)

A document's text content can be extracted, read, and confirmed correct – every word right, every section present – while the rendering is still broken. Found in this project: a non-negotiables list where the docx-generation code applied Word's native auto-numbering and also hardcoded a literal '1.', '2.' prefix into each list item's own text, producing a doubled '1. 1. Do not...' / '2. 2. Do not...' result that plain-text extraction (pandoc, raw XML text parsing) does not surface, because the extracted text technically reads fine linearly.

This is why opening the actual file in a real Word renderer is not optional (Section 5.15) – some defects only exist in how content is combined with structure, and a text-only check will pass a genuinely broken file.

Any time a build process combines native Word numbering/bullets with manually-written ordinal prefixes in the same list, check the rendered output specifically for doubled numbers.

Pattern I – Rule 2.8's References bug recurring in already-committed chapters

(New this session.)

The Rule 2.8 'internal documents in References' bug was first found and fixed in AAC.1-8. It was assumed fixed project-wide afterward. It was not: the same generator-level bug was found independently in PRE.1-4 – files that had already been committed and treated as 'done' for the entire project's duration up to this point.

'Already committed' and 'already audited' are not the same claim. A generator-level bug fixed in one chapter does not mean it was fixed everywhere that chapter's generator (or a sibling generator built

the same way) touched. Any chapter using a generator script that has ever shown this bug anywhere should be re-checked for it specifically, even if it was committed and 'finished' long ago.

Section 5 – Verification Loop (run all of this, every standard)

This is the process that catches the errors above. Skipping any step is how a wrong rule or a broken file reaches a finished document.

5.1 – Pull and verify the source

Get the raw OE text and Guidebook interpretation for every objective element in the standard, verbatim, from the actual HCO 6th Edition source (see Section 0). Never draft from memory or by pattern-matching a previous chapter. Check for truncation/corruption before using it.

5.2 – Cross-check against the real Guidebook pages

If the person can supply the actual Guidebook PDF pages for the chapter, cross-check the dump against them before drafting – this is what caught Pattern E in HRM before any content was written, and Pattern G in PRE after the fact. Don't skip this step just because a dump 'looks' complete.

5.3 – Draft

Follow Sections 1–3 above. Flag, in writing, any standard with stop-work data, naming exactly which OEs trigger it (Pattern E).

5.4 – Overlap check

Explicitly compare the new draft's sentences against every previously-approved document in the chapter. Report which sentences overlap and why (shared boilerplate vs. borrowed content) – even an answer of 'no reuse found' should be stated, not assumed.

5.5 – Build

Generate the actual .docx file.

5.6 – Guillemet audit

Search the rendered text for every «» occurrence. The only string that should ever appear inside guillemets is 'Hospital Name'. Anything else – a role, a frequency, a timeframe – is a Rule 3.2 violation.

5.7 – Cross-reference leak audit (Pattern D)

Search for every occurrence of a standard-code pattern (e.g. [A-Z]{2,4}\.[0-9]+(\.[a-z])?) in the rendered text. Every hit should belong to the standard's own code. Any hit from a different chapter, or a different standard within the same chapter, is a leak – fix by rephrasing as 'covered in other hospital policies' (different standard) or an internal section pointer (same standard).

5.7 now additionally requires: search Purpose and Scope sections specifically for the document's OWN standard code (e.g., an AAC.1 document searched for 'AAC.1'), not just foreign-standard codes. A same-standard code reference in Purpose/Scope is now also a Rule 2.5 violation per the updated rule above, not an acceptable internal pointer – internal pointers belong only inside body prose as 'Section 5.3'-style references, never in Purpose or Scope.

5.8 – References / Rule 2.8 audit (Pattern I) [extended v1.8]

Search for ‘internal document’ (or similar) inside the References section specifically. It should never appear there. Confirm References contains only the NABH Guidebook citation and any genuinely named external law/standard.

Additionally — mandatory explicit pattern search [NEW v1.8]: Search every References section for the exact string “Guidebook interpretation supplied for” (and close variants such as “supplied for [CODE].a through [CODE].[letter]” or “...supplied for [CODE].[letter]-[letter]”). This is a confirmed recurring generator artefact — an internal build note describing what source material was given to the drafting tool, not a real external citation. It has no value as a reference entry and must never be retained in a document a hospital or assessor reads.

Confirmed history of this artefact: first found and removed from AAC.9-13; independently found again across all 20 COP documents (COP.1-20), confirming it is not chapter-specific and not fixed by cleaning one chapter. Any document found with this pattern must have the line deleted from References. Do not assume it is absent in a chapter simply because a previous chapter was cleaned — each chapter’s References section must be searched independently on every audit pass.

5.9 – CORE/asterisk inline-sentence audit (Pattern C)

Search for phrases like ‘is a CORE element,’ ‘is an asterisked element,’ ‘core objective element’ inside the body prose (not the Traceability table). None should appear.

5.10 – Fabricated-frequency audit (Pattern G)

Search for frequency/interval words (annually, quarterly, monthly, every year, X days, X hours) anywhere in the document. For each hit, confirm it traces to an actual number stated in the OE or Guidebook Interpretation text – not a dump’s illustrative commentary, and not something invented to fill a template field. The one universal exception is the fixed disclaimer’s own ‘reviewed at least once every year’ boilerplate line, which is administrative housekeeping applied identically to every document, not a sourced NABH requirement.

5.10 now additionally requires: for every time value that passes the existing fabrication check (i.e., it IS a real, intentional number, not an obvious fabrication), confirm a citation for that exact value exists in the standard’s References section – either the existing NABH Guidebook citation (if NABH states the number) or a named external source (if adopted per Rule 2.9/2.10). A time value with no traceable citation anywhere in the document, even if not fabricated-looking, is a Rule 2.10 violation and must be flagged.

5.11 – Stop-work tagging audit (Pattern E)

For any standard with a Stop-work section, check the Traceability table’s ‘Where addressed’ column OE by OE. Only the specific OEs confirmed to trigger stop-work in the source should carry the stop-work reference. Every other OE in that standard should show only its normal Section 5 subsection reference.

5.12 – Template boilerplate audit (Pattern F, Rule 2.7)

Search for ‘Do not skip:’ followed by what looks like a restated OE sentence, and for ‘Method note’ or similar internal-build-artefact labels. None should appear.

5.13 – Paragraph style / structure check

Open the docx's underlying XML (or use a script) and confirm: the title uses the Title style (not Heading 1 or bold Normal text), top-level sections use Heading 1, subsections use Heading 2. Don't trust how it looks rendered – verify the actual style object.

5.14 – Visual render check

Convert the docx to PDF/images and look at it. Specifically check: the Document Control table, the Traceability table (does the Level column show the right CORE/Commitment/Achievement/Excellence/asterisk value per OE?), the staff sign-off table (does it render as a real multi-row table, not a single-person block?), and the Disclaimer.

5.15 – Open the real file in Word (Pattern H – not optional)

A text-extraction pass and even a rendered-PDF check can both pass a file that is still broken – the IMS non-negotiables double-numbering bug did exactly this. Before treating any batch of files as final, open at least one or two of them in actual Microsoft Word and read them like a human would. Look specifically at numbered/bulleted lists for doubling, and confirm there are no compatibility warnings on open.

5.16 – Confirm before committing

Only after every check above passes should a file move toward being staged and committed. If any check fails, fix and re-run all of the checks – not just the one that failed – since a fix can introduce a new problem elsewhere (as happened when the first 'Internal documents' fix attempt in one chapter left a different chapter's version of the same bug unfixed).

5.17 – Verified-practice source audit [extended v1.5]

For any standard where a number/frequency was filled per Rule 2.9, confirm:

- The external source is named in-line in the policy text (not just in References).
- The link in References is live and actually supports the stated number – fetch and check it, don't assume.
- The phrasing doesn't claim or imply NABH mandates it.
- The source is a real, checkable, professional/international body's guidance – not a blog, forum, or unverifiable page.

5.17 now additionally requires, for every external Reference URL in every document: actually fetch the URL's live content – Claude Code has confirmed web-fetch capability in this environment; use it, and do not defer to 'needs manual verification.' Extract the fetched page's real title, publisher, and what it actually says. Compare that against what the document's citation claims it supports. A mismatch – wrong body, wrong topic, a withdrawn or cancelled study, a dead link, or content that does not address the specific number or practice being cited – is a confirmed Rule 2.9/2.10 violation to report and fix, not a flag to defer.

5.18 – Undefined shorthand audit [NEW v1.6]

For every compound or shorthand term used in the document as if self-explanatory (e.g., a hyphenated noun phrase like 'temporary-holding over-run' or 'priority-flag lapse'), confirm that the term was defined in plain language at its first occurrence in the same document. A shorthand term

used before its definition, or never defined at all, is a Rule 2.5d violation. Flag it and either replace the bare label with the full concept at each point of use, or insert the definition at first occurrence.

5.19 – Deferred-definition audit [NEW v1.6]

For every ‘the organisation’s defined [X]’ or similar deferral phrase found in the document, confirm the sentence also names where that definition lives – a specific SOP, a named role responsible for maintaining it, or a cross-reference to a real governance document. A deferral with no named home is a Rule 2.5e violation. Fix it by adding the home (e.g., ‘as defined by the Quality Coordinator in the Incident Management SOP’), or – if no governance document for it currently exists – flag it as a gap for the organisation to fill before the policy is finalised.

5.20 – Dead reference audit [NEW v1.7]

For every “refer to,” “see,” or similar pointer phrase in the document, confirm the referenced resource is either:

- present in this same document (an actual Glossary section, an Appendix, a named table that exists in the rendered file), or
- named precisely enough for the reader to locate it independently — a specific document title, section number, page reference, or URL.

A pointer that satisfies neither condition — e.g., “refer to the Glossary” when no glossary exists in the document and no glossary is named as a findable external source — is a dead pointer (Rule 2.5f violation). Fix by either including the referenced content at the point of use or replacing the bare reference with a precise locator (e.g., “see the NABH Guidebook to Accreditation Standards for Hospitals, 6th Edition, Glossary of Terms”).

This check applies to every document regardless of chapter. Pointer phrases to search for include: “refer to the Glossary,” “see Appendix,” “refer to the policy on,” “as defined in the attached table,” “see the list below” (where no list follows), “see Section” (where the named section does not exist), and similar constructions.

Section 6 – Git Discipline

- Every session, first thing, in a new cmd/PowerShell window (not the Claude Code bash-hook terminal, which has a known non-blocking rtk: command not found error that makes its own git output untrustworthy to read past): `git fetch` then `git log -1 --oneline` .
- Git commands run one at a time, never chained with `&&`, when typed directly into cmd by a person.
- Never `git add .` – Stage explicit file lists only.
- After staging, always run `git status --short` (full output, not a collapsed pane) and confirm the staged file list exactly matches intent before committing. This has caught real discrepancies more than once – a tool’s own narrated summary of ‘what’s staged’ is not verification; check the actual git status output.
- When a file already exists on master and a fix touches it, do not assume M in git status means real content changed. Diff the actual document.xml (or equivalent) between the committed version and the working copy. If the diff is empty, it’s container noise (a real, repeated finding in

this project – COP.1-6, PSQ.1, and HRM.1-5 all showed this at different points) and should not be re-staged. If the diff is non-empty, it's a real change and belongs in the commit.

- A plain local git commit is a low-stakes, reversible action. Verify the staged file list once or twice, then commit – don't loop indefinitely re-checking a reversible step.
- Instructions meant for an agentic coding tool (plain-English task descriptions) should never be handed to a person to type directly into a raw cmd window – they fail as unrecognized commands. Give literal, paste-ready shell commands for direct typing; plain-English task descriptions only when relayed through the coding tool itself.

Section 7 – Official Chapter and Standard Counts

Per the NABH 6th Edition Guidebook's own 'Summary of Chapters, Standards and Objective Elements' table. Verify against a chapter's actual Guidebook page before drafting – this project has miscounted before.

- AAC: 13 standards
- COP: 20 standards
- MOM: 11 standards
- PRE: 8 standards
- IPC: 8 standards
- PSQ: 7 standards
- ROM: 6 standards
- FMS: 7 standards
- HRM: 13 standards
- IMS: 7 standards
- Total: 100 standards

A chapter's docx file existing on disk is not the same as that chapter being verified. Track three separate states per chapter: built (a docx exists), mechanically fixed (got a References-line or similar automated pass), and audited (went through the full Verification Loop in Section 5 against real source pages). Only the third state should be reported as 'done' without a caveat.

Disclaimer

This document is an internal working reference compiled for the AccredReady / HCO Full v2 policy rewrite project. It consolidates the project's original rulebook with defects and patterns found and fixed during actual drafting work. It is not itself an NABH publication and creates no accreditation obligation on its own – the authoritative source for any standard's content remains the real NABH HCO Full Accreditation 6th Edition Standards and Guidebook.